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AFP

VIDEO OF BOUND GAZA AID FLOTILLA ACTIVISTS SPARKS OUTRAGE

■ This screen grab taken from footage released on Israeli National Security Minister Itamar Ben Gvir's X account on Wednesday shows dozens of detained activists from the Gaza-bound aid flotilla kneeling with their hands tied behind their backs and foreheads on the ground inside a detention centre in Israel. The video, published after Israeli forces intercepted the flotilla's vessels at sea and began detaining hundreds of foreign activists at the southern port of Ashdod, has sparked international condemnation. **SEE ALSO P12**

Dubai clears Dh1.5b in incentives

33 initiatives to aid education, trade, tourism and customs

DUBAI

BY JUSTIN VARGHESE
Your Money Editor

Dubai has approved a second economic incentives package worth Dh1.5 billion, expanding its broader support drive to Dh2.5 billion within two months as the emirate pushes to strengthen business resilience and competitiveness.

The package, approved by Sheikh Hamdan Bin Mohammed Bin Rashid Al Maktoum, Crown Prince of Dubai, Deputy

Prime Minister and Minister of Defence of the UAE, and Chairman of Dubai Executive Council, includes 33 initiatives targeting tourism, trade, customs, aviation, transport and education. Measures will be rolled out over periods ranging from three to 12 months.

Key incentives

Key incentives include exemptions from tourism dirham fees, municipal charges on hotel room and restaurant sales, and permit-related event fees. Companies registered with the Mohammed Bin Rashid Establishment for Small and Medium Enterprises will receive a two-year extension on membership

licences, along with exemptions on sales and promotional fees.

The package introduces customs payment instalment options, an 80 per cent reduction in customs fines, deferred licence renewal fees for private schools and lower renewal costs for civil aviation activity permits.

Dubai had earlier announced a Dh1 billion support package in March focused on fee deferrals, customs relief and hospitality sector support. Officials said the latest measures are designed to strengthen public-private partnerships, improve liquidity for businesses and reinforce Dubai's position as a global economic hub.

SEE ALSO P7

UAE to benefit as UK signs landmark GCC trade deal

Deal strengthens UAE's role as a regional trade and investment hub

DUBAI

BY JUSTIN VARGHESE
Your Money Editor

The United Kingdom signed a free-trade agreement with the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC), becoming the first G7 country to secure a trade pact with the six-member bloc that includes the UAE, Saudi Arabia, Bahrain, Kuwait, Oman and Qatar.

The agreement is expected to strengthen the UAE's role as a regional hub for trade, logistics, finance and investment flows between Britain and the Gulf. Britain's Department for Business and Trade said the deal could add £3.7 billion annually

to the UK economy over the long term and boost bilateral trade by nearly 20 per cent.

The agreement includes measures to reduce trade barriers, speed up customs clearances and improve market access for services firms. Tariffs worth around £580 million annually on UK exports to the Gulf are expected to be eliminated over time, with £360 million removed immediately once the agreement takes effect. The deal also contains digital trade provisions allowing UK companies to store and process data outside the Gulf region, reducing operating costs.

British Prime Minister Keir Starmer described the agreement as a major boost for businesses and workers, while officials said it would strengthen long-term economic resilience amid rising geopolitical uncertainty.

SEE ALSO P9

UAE WARNS IRAN AGAINST 'NEW REALITY' IN HORMUZ

Iranian 'bullying' destroyed trust: Gargash

DUBAI

BY STEPHEN N. R.
Senior Associate Editor

Dr Anwar Gargash, Diplomatic Adviser to the UAE President, said the Iranian bullying has eroded trust, warning that attempts to impose a new regional reality following its recent military setbacks would not succeed.

In a post on X platform, Gargash said the Gulf region had grown accustomed over decades to what he called Iranian "bullying", adding that its credibility had been lost between aggressive political discourse and what he described as hollow statements of friendship.

"After the brutal Iranian aggression, Tehran's regime was attempting to solidify a new reality born out of an obvious military defeat", Gargash said, adding that attempts to control the Strait of Hormuz or infringe upon the UAE's maritime sovereignty were unrealistic and would remain just wishful thinking."

Slogans cannot restore trust

He said whoever seeks co-existence with its Arab neighbours must recognise that trust had been lost and could not be restored through slogans alone.

"Trust can only be rebuilt through responsible language, respect for sovereignty and genuine commitment to the principles of good neighbourliness," Gargash emphasised.

Germany, meanwhile, reaffirmed support for the UAE and condemned the recent drone attack launched from Iraqi territory targeting the Barakah Nuclear Power Plant facility in Abu Dhabi during talks between Chancellor Friedrich Merz and Sheikh Abdullah

TRUMP-NETANYAHU SPLIT WIDENS OVER IRAN

A sharp divide has emerged between US President Donald Trump and Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu over whether to resume military action against Iran, as tense diplomacy and war planning now appear to be running in parallel behind the scenes.

A heated hour-long phone call between the two leaders on Tuesday exposed growing frustration inside the Israeli leadership after Trump abruptly paused a planned new wave of US strikes on Iran — an operation reportedly set to be renamed "Operation Sledgehammer."

According to CNN and Axios, Netanyahu pushed Trump to press ahead with the attacks, arguing that delaying military action would only allow Tehran more time to regroup, rebuild and drag out negotiations. Trump, however, insisted that diplomacy should be given "a few more days" before another round of strikes is launched.

—S. N. R.

Bin Zayed Al Nahyan, Deputy Prime Minister and Minister of Foreign Affairs.

Gargash's remarks came as Iran's newly established PGSA maritime authority has published what it described as the boundaries of its Hormuz "management supervision area", fuelling concerns that Tehran is attempting to formalise greater control over the strategic waterway after months of conflict and disruption to global shipping.

The deadlock over US-Iran peace talks also continued yesterday, with neither side showing signs of backing down from core demands even as regional mediators intensified diplomatic efforts.

Pakistan's Interior Minister Mohsin Naqvi this week met Iran's parliament speaker and chief negotiator Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf in Tehran, while Pakistani chief of Defence Forces Asim Munir was expected in the Iranian capital later yesterday.

US Secretary of State Marco Rubio said Washington hoped Pakistan's diplomacy could help move negotiations for-

ward. "I believe the Pakistanis will be travelling to Tehran today. So hopefully that'll advance this further," Rubio told reporters.

'On the borderline'

US President Donald Trump said Wednesday that negotiations were "on the borderline" between a breakthrough and renewed military strikes.

At the same time, CNN reported that US intelligence believes Iran has already resumed parts of its drone manufacturing programme during the ceasefire, suggesting Tehran is rebuilding military capabilities far faster than initially expected.

Meanwhile, concerns are also mounting over the global energy market.

Fatih Birol, head of the International Energy Agency, warned that oil markets risk entering a "red zone" by summer if the conflict continues unresolved. "We may be entering the red zone in July or August if we don't see improvements in the situation," he said at London's Chatham House.

SEE ALSO P4, 6, 11

Ships stuck in Gulf waters face barnacles, jellyfish threat: Reports

Marine growth, heat, delays worsen conditions for stranded ships, crews

DUBAI

BY DHANUSHA GOKULAN
Chief Reporter

Ships stranded in Gulf waters for weeks are now facing an unusual new problem — barnacles, algae and jellyfish are building up on their hulls and propellers, raising concerns that some vessels could struggle to leave even after the regional conflict eases.

According to the *Financial Times*, at least 800 merchant ships remain stranded in Gulf waters since February 28, leaving around 20,000 seafarers on board carrying out basic maintenance as they wait. But long periods at anchor in the Gulf's warm, shallow waters are now creating a fresh challenge. "When you don't move... you have a lot of fouling growing," said Lasse Kristoffersen, chief executive of Wallenius Wilhelmsen, which has one ship stuck in the Gulf.

Marine growth such as barnacles, algae and jellyfish can clog protective gratings and interfere

with pipe systems. It can also attach to ship hulls and propellers, creating drag that slows vessels down and increases fuel use. Rolf Habben Jansen, chief executive of Hapag-Lloyd, told FT: "The main surprise was the amount of fouling we had on the ship," he said, adding that after spending six to eight weeks in waters of around 30C, "there was a lot of stuff that gets attached to the ship that you really don't want to have attached to the ship."

Hapag-Lloyd told FT that marine growth and barnacles covered all of the ship's propeller, much of its vertical sides and about 40 per cent of its bottom. Habben Jansen said "quite a lot of cleaning" would now have to be considered for the company's remaining ships trapped in the Gulf. Shipping executives say fouling also raises fuel consumption because the ship has to work harder to move through the water. The marine growth issue comes on top of a wider regional shipping disruption that has already sharply increased costs and delayed cargo.



ENTERTAINMENT

UAE National Orchestra to train promising Emirati musicians | P15